Realism of Beauty Defended

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Abstract:

The stance I intend to defend is called Realism of Beauty, which indicates that beauty is in objects rather than in subjects. The idea behind this view is that those philosophers who endorse this version of realism want to save the ontological stance of beauty, namely, they tend to say that a beautiful thing is ‘‘beautiful in itself’’ even if no subjects or observers exist in the world. In this sense, the subjective feeling of beauty stems from discovering objects instead of creating the feeling merely in our own minds. Furthermore, if I say a thing is beautiful, I am representing a fact. In this article, I will give three arguments to justify this view.

Keywords: Realism of Beauty, Mind-independent, Substantive properties, Verdictive properties, Supervenience

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美實在論的辯護

賴文*

摘要：

在本篇文章中筆者欲辯護的立場為美的實在論，此種立場認為美的性質在對象裡而不在主體中。這立場背後的想法是實在論者們意圖保護美的存有論地位:他們認為美的對象本身就是美的，即使世界上沒有任何一個人存在。在這個意義下，美的感受來自於發現對象中美的性質，而不是在心中創造出美的感受。進一步來說，當我說一個對象是美的，我在表徵一個事實。在這篇文章中，我會給三個論證來支持此種立場。

關鍵詞：美的實在論、獨立於心靈的存在、實在性質、評價性質、隨附

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Introduction

When we argue about beauty, are we arguing about our personal preference or a fact in reality? In this essay, I endorse the second view which can be named as realism of beauty. In this view, beauty is a property in the object; when this property is really in a certain artwork and therefore I state: ‘‘this artwork is beautiful’’, I represent a fact in reality instead of merely stating my personal preference. Hence, in aesthetic judgment, my statement of beauty expresses a ‘belief’ about the object rather than my preference. Thus, this is the cognitivist's stance which treats our judgment of beauty as representing a fact about an object instead of merely expressing our preference.

In this context, if beauty is a kind of property, what is its relation to other kinds of properties? I take Zangwill's (1995) and Levinson's (2006) views on this topic. In light of them, there are two kinds of property: substantive property and verdictive property. I intend to argue that the relation between substantive properties and verdictive properties is supervenience. In this article, we only aim at dealing with two components in the verdictive properties: beauty and ugliness. Furthermore, the substantive and the verdictive properties are mind-independent. Therefore, the statement of beauty represents a fact. In the first section, I will argue that this metaphysical stance of beauty is held by offering the arguments.

When I state: ‘‘this painting is beautiful’’, I am representing a fact. However, what is the representational state and what kind of mental events are not representational state? When I experience an artwork and enjoy its beauty, what is the structure of this experience? In my interpretation, we have phenomenal experience (it includes sensory experience and seeing-as experience) towards the object and then produce the judgment. But how this

account supports the realism of beauty? In my view, because the sensory experience relates to the physical and the substantive properties of the object, and the seeing-as experience are 'of' the substantive and the verdictive properties. Hence, this view will support the realism of beauty. In the second section, I will flesh out these ideas.

However, why I assert that if the substantive properties change, the verdictive properties will not necessarily change? In order to address this issue, we need to introduce the concepts of type identity and token identity.

I propose that when we talk about beauty in general, the relation between substantive properties and verdictive properties is token identity. Nevertheless, if we concentrate on specific kind of beauty such as gracefully beautiful, the relation between verdictive properties and substantive properties is type identity. In third section, I will explicate this view.

1. Substantive vs. verdictive properties and their ontological status

In the first place, we should distinguish two realms: mind and reality. For instance, I say ''strawberry ice cream is better than chocolate ice cream''. This sentence only corresponds to my psychological state rather than representing a fact in reality. What I refer to by saying ''strawberry ice cream is better than chocolate ice cream'' is my psychological state. However, when I see a ball in front of me, I say: ''this ball is round''. What I am doing is representing a fact that the ball is round in reality. Even if I use the mental faculty and perceive that this ball is round, I really say something which represents a fact in reality.

What is representing a fact? We can depict this conception in this manner: when a sentence corresponds rightly to a psychological state or state of affairs, this sentence represents a fact. Parallelly, the state being rightly corresponded is a fact. Nevertheless, we have to separate two kinds of fact: physical fact and

psychological fact. When the sentence ‘‘this ball is round’’ corresponds to the roundness of this ball, it is a physical fact since the roundness of this ball is in reality (the roundness of this ball, in a sense, has nothing to do with my mind). A psychological fact indicates that when I say ‘‘strawberry ice cream is better than chocolate ice cream’’ corresponds to my psychological state (my personal preference instead of objective fact), this state is a psychological fact. In a sense, the sentence of taste just expresses my mental state, not to represent a fact in reality. In a nutshell, the physical fact is outside our mind while the psychological fact is not. There is another difference between the psychological fact and the physical fact. The psychological fact could only (currently) be perceived by the subject who is having it. The physical fact has the objectivity since everyone could perceive it and has less room for arguing than the psychological fact.

Here raises a problem: psychological or neurological state is part of reality, how can we separate our relevant mental state from reality? I would like to respond to this question in this way: even though the psychological and the neurological state which causes us to have certain mental state are in reality, but this state is of our mind rather than of the object. I intend to distinguish the psychological and the physical fact because in this article, when we state something as beautiful, we must be clear about we are stating a psychological fact or a physical fact of artwork. In order to draw the picture of realism and anti-realism of beauty, this dichotomy is inevitable. The realism I intend to defend here is that judgment of beauty is representing a physical fact.

Is the realism of beauty here compatible with cognitivist's stance in aesthetics? I tend to answer yes. In cognitivist's stance in aesthetics, when I judge something to be beautiful, I am forming a belief which has truth-value of a physical fact or a psychological fact. Hence, the statement ‘‘x is beautiful’’

is true or false depends on my psychological state or whether this artwork contains the property of beauty.

Unlike the non-cognitivist's view (for example, expressivist), in which when I say ‘‘this artwork is beautiful’’, this claim does not describe anything other than ‘‘I approve of this!’’, in which this statement lacks the truth-value because it corresponds to nothing. However, we need the argument to support the realism and cognitivist's idea. Thus, we should firstly understand the conception of the substantive properties and the verdictive properties.

First, we must distinguish two kinds of properties: the substantive properties and the verdictive properties (Zangwill 1995, 320-1). The substantive properties such as gaudiness, balance and so on are constituted by lower-level physical properties. In a sense, the constitution means when lower-level physical properties are arranged in a certain way, everyone will experience this arrangement as ‘‘gaudiness’’ or ‘‘balance’’. It follows that the substantive properties are more or less descriptive of certain object rather than intrinsically evaluative.

If we accept this view, then substantive terms seems to have descriptive and evaluative content. For this kind of properties are constituted by physical properties, in this sense, the terms which express them seem to have descriptive content. For instance, if the colors of this cloth are bright and diverse enough to a certain degree (we can use the machine to detect the wave length of these colors), then we can call this cloth is gaudy. Because color is constituted by its wave length and light condition, in the same environment, everyone with the same faculty would perceive the same qualia. Take a more uncontroversial example like balance. If a painting can be cut into two pieces from the central line, and two pieces are completely symmetrical, the term balance which expresses our visual image of this painting is seemingly a descriptive term.

Here is the follow-up problem: some substantive terms seem to be evaluative per se. If I remove the evaluative content of some terms, then these terms have no meaning at all. Take for example, when I say this cloth is gaudy, some people would think that my expression is debunking its merit; when I say this painting gives him the feeling of balance, some would think that this painting is good based on my expression.

Zangwill (1995, 323) and Levinson (2006, 317) used Grice's view to make appear the descriptive content of the substantive term. Some evaluative contents of a substantive term are just our conversational implicature: it means that this term is not intrinsically evaluative, its evaluative contents are added by us. How can we identity this kind of substantive terms (evaluation-added)? In my interpretation, Grice's view is that if a substantive term can simultaneously positively and negatively be used to describe objects, then this term is not intrinsically evaluative. To wit, this term is not intrinsically evaluative so that its two-sided evaluative contents can be cancelled. For instance, we can say wonderfully gaudy or terribly gaudy towards objects; thus, this term is not intrinsically evaluative.

In order to distinguish the substantive terms from intrinsically evaluative terms, we can see Grice's original approach on this issue:

Second, cancelability. You will remember that a putative conversational implicature that p is explicitly cancelable if, to the form of words the utterance of which putatively implicates that p, it is admissible to add *but not* p, or I do not mean to imply that p, and it is contextually cancelable if one can find situations in which the utterance of the form of words would simply not carry the implicature (Grice 1989, 44).

On his account, beauty is instrinsically evaluative because it is unlikely to say that ‘x is terribly beautiful’. Therefore, this term is not a substantive term.

Nonetheless, the consequence caused by Grice is not very clear-cut: a term can only be used positively or negatively, or it can be used both ways depends on people. There is no agreement on whether a term's conversational implicature is cancellable or not. For instance, some people would agree that we can use ‘terribly graceful’ and some would not. We cannot solve this problem here, this issue is that roughly, we can say a term has descriptive content and not intrinsically evaluative if it could be used (by some people) positively and negatively at the same time. We can view Gricean test as such: it cannot conclusively decide which terms are substantive, however in terms of beauty and ugliness, they are certainly not the substantive terms because we will not say ‘terribly beautiful’ or ‘wonderfully ugly’.

Verdictive properties in this article will be limited to only two kinds: beauty and ugliness. Since our main concern in this essay is the realism of beauty, we only discuss these two kinds of verdictive properties. In my view, the relation between the substantive properties and the verdictive properties is that the latter supervenes on the former. It means that without the substantive properties, there are certainly no verdictive properties. If the verdictive properties change (for example, when beauty becomes ugliness), the substantive properties will change also. Yet if substantive properties alter, verdictive properties will change accordingly? This is not the case in my interpretation since general beauty can be multiply realized in different substantive properties. I will turn back to this point in section 3.

Because of this relation, the verdictive properties are constituted by the substantive properties. Hence, we can make the arguments about the realism of beauty as follows:

Argument 1

P1: Substantive terms have descriptive and evaluative content.

P2: If a term has descriptive content, then its properties being described are mind-independent.

C: Substantive properties are mind-independent.

Argument 2

P1: Substantive properties are mind-independent.

P2: Verdictive properties are constituted by substantive properties.

P3: If a property is constituted by substantive properties, then this property is mind-independent.

C: Verdictive properties are mind-independent.

(Even if beauty or ugliness partly depends on my feeling, they are mind-independent properties; when we do not experience it, it is still there but exists as a disposition)

Argument 3

P1: If a property is mind-independent, when we experience it and then describe it, we are representing a fact.

P2: Verdictive properties are beauty and ugliness, these properties are mind-independent.

C: If we experience beauty and then describe it, we are representing a fact.

2. Representation and phenomenal experience

In the case of beauty, our experience and judgment of beauty are of the mind-independent property. Thus, our statement of beauty has truth-value corresponding to the object, in this sense, we are representing a fact. However, in aesthetic experience, what is the structure of our experience in the sense of realism? If the content of this kind of experience is about the object and about mind-independent properties, then this view of experience can support the

realism of beauty.

First, our aesthetic experience is a representational state since this experience is of the physical object. What is the representational state? I employ Rowe's view:

The answer, surely, is that the objects of the aesthetic senses have *parts* which are laid out on spatial temporal or spatiotemporal fields, and that it therefore makes sense to talk about up/down, left/right, before/after, or some combination of these with reference to works of art (Rowe 1999, 42).

Suppose I am looking at the Mona Lisa, my phenomenal experience has created a mental three-dimensional space. In this space, I notice the color and line as moving, and I also can experience that her upper body is closer to me than the background and so forth. In listening to a symphony, I experience the pitch is moving high and down in my head, like the water flow through my head; I can even experience a sound is flying away from me.

In these two cases, I experience the substantive properties and the verdictive properties so that I judge this painting or this symphony is beautiful. In my interpretation, ‘‘my representing is of something in reality and of mind-independent properties’’.

Still, what kind of experience is not the representational state? Some experiences like emotional distress and anxiety, in these cases I only feel the distress and anxiety. That is all, I do not create a mental three-dimensional space as to my distress and anxiety. On the other hand, although the emotion is caused and can be realized in neurological state; presumably someone can say that when he or she is experiencing emotion, he is representing a fact in neurological level. However, my response will be that when you experience an artwork, you experience the physical arrangement, the substantive properties and the verdictive properties; but when you experience distress or anxiety, you only experience this ‘feeling’ but do not experience the

underlying physical and neurological state.

Thus, at least in my interpretation, representational state contains the three-dimensional experience, and also contains the experience of the physical arrangement which give rise to the three-dimensional experience. Simply put, I am in representational state if I experience the physical layer and the supervenient layer. In the case of the distress and the anxiety, I only experience the supervenient layer (my feeling) but nothing of physical layer.

The next issue is: what is the structure of the aesthetic experience? Can we add more details on this representational state? As mentioned in Introduction, in aesthetics, we experience an artwork (phenomenal experience) and will subsequently have the judgment. Within the phenomenal experience, we can roughly divide two kinds of experience: sensory experience and seeing-as experience. This view is stated by Stokes (2018). What is the relation between these two experiences? Why do I put them into the same category of phenomenal experience?

Phenomenal experience includes my sensory experience (vision, hearing and so on) and seeing-as experience. When I look at da Vinci's Mona Lisa, I will experience its line, color and arrangement as sensory properties. This is sensory experience. Moreover, I see this painting as graceful, serene, beautiful and most importantly, as Mona Lisa (seeing-as experience). This seeing-as experience is like I grasp the wholeness of these sensory properties and then in this kind of experience, I experience the ‘emergence’ of the combination of these sensory properties. In this context, our phenomenal experience includes the sensory experience and seeing-as experience. Then I judge ‘‘this painting is beautiful’’.

We can treat our phenomenal experience as a process of completing a jigsaw puzzle. Every sensory experience is a piece, when we combine these pieces to the extent that this jigsaw puzzle is finished, the whole imagery

suddenly emerges. This whole imagery is the seeing-as experience. It should be noted that the seeing-as experience is not merely seeing this jigsaw puzzle as representing Mona Lisa, this kind of experience also lead us to experience 'as if' this imagery is moving slowly, the woman is sitting in the middle of the imagery, the background is moving backward and then manifest the woman and so forth.

The jigsaw-puzzle metaphor can be employed to explicate the sensory and the seeing-as experiences, nevertheless, this metaphor in some respect is not so accurate. At first glance, we can roughly understand how to divide the sensory experience and the seeing-as experience through this metaphor; however, in some respect this metaphor is not completely right.

First, in most cases of appreciating an artwork, we initially grasp the whole and then experience the sensory properties. When I see the painting of Mona Lisa, the first image that comes to my eyes is the whole scene of this painting. I experience the moving line, the smile of that woman and I feel serene and graceful towards this painting. Subsequently, I start to notice the detail (sensory properties) such as color, line, texture and relevant sensory properties. This up-to-bottom experience contradicts jigsaw-puzzle metaphor in which sensory experience constitutes the seeing-as experience in sequence. Perhaps, ontologically, we quickly gather our sensory experiences altogether and then produce the seeing-as experience. It might be that our experience lie to us that we firstly grasp the whole and then notice each pieces. Currently, we cannot ensure how our cognition really functions; at least according to our daily experience, the metaphor of jigsaw puzzle is not very persuasive.

Another problem of this metaphor is that we cannot draw a clear line between the sensory experience and the seeing-as experience. In terms of completing the jigsaw puzzle, we can clearly distinguish the process of combing these pieces and appreciating the work-has-been-done. But in the

aesthetic experience, it seems that the sensory experience and the seeing-as experience are intertwined.

According to the reason above given, I put two kinds of experience into the same category (phenomenal experience). Some may argue that we can draw a clear line between the sensory experience and the seeing-as experience through treating the former as experiencing the physical properties and arrangement, the latter as experiencing the feeling and representing something. Nevertheless, this thought is very similar to jigsaw-puzzle metaphor rejected above. At best, and very roughly, we can claim that the seeing-as experience is like experiencing the emergence of the combination of each parts; and sensory experience is more like experience of grasping and combining these separated parts.

Of greater importance, accordingly the sensory experience is of the physical and the substantive properties and the seeing-as experience is of the substantive and the verdictive properties, if this is right, then our experiencing is of mind-independent properties. Hence, we are representing a fact when experiencing (the sensory and the seeing-as experience) an artwork. This may give some strength to the beauty realist.

3. Type identity and token identity

As previously asserted, the change of the substantive properties will not necessarily cause the verdictive properties to change. How is this assertion being made?

Take the following view (Bickle 1998, 116-24): A type of mental state can only be realized in one type of physical state, and an instance of this type of mental state can only be realized in an instance of this type of physical state. If we hold this view, we are siding with type identity. If a type of mental state can be realized in multiple types of physical states (the mental state of pain

can be realized in my physical state and in a cutting-edge robot's mental state, for example); and an instance of this type of mental state can be realized in multiple instances of different types of physical state. The latter named token identity.

If we treat beauty as a property, namely, objectify its existence; then which view is more suitable to explain beauty? I propose that beauty is something in between.

The relation between verdictive properties and substantive properties is supervenience. The latter constitute the former. However, we can allow the possibility that beauty (a type) be realized in different substantive properties (different types). For example, certainly, other substantive properties like violence and sublime can produce the beauty. On the other hand, an instance of beauty cannot be realized in different substantive properties. For instance, graceful beauty can only be produced by substantive properties of gracefulness. I cannot think of other possibilities.

Even if beauty is a verdictive property, this property contains diverse elements according to which this property itself can be constituted by different substantive properties. However, if we are taking closer look at specific beauty, there are plenty kinds of beauty such as graceful beauty, violent beauty, beauty of sublime and so forth. Following this line of thought, since the property of beauty contains diverse elements and therefore different kinds of beauty exist, ‘general beauty’ can be realized in different substantive properties.

Yet someone may ask, why ‘specific beauty’ could not allow multiple realizability? For instance, graceful beauty when you are looking at Mona Lisa could also be realized in Maria Theresia painted by Bucquoi Elisabeth. Apparently, this is a counter-example against my view.

Here is my response: experientially, at least Mona Lisa and Maria

Theresia share one of substantive properties: gracefulness. Although these two painting are diverse in some respect, whereas they do both have the property of gracefulness. In a strict sense, graceful beauty can only be realized in the same substantive property (gracefulness) even though these two painting have their different combinations of substantive properties.

Perhaps the thing goes like this: it could be the case that graceful beauty is realized in different conjunctions of different substantive properties (the conjunction of gracefulness, balance, calmness or the conjunction of gracefulness, harmony etc.), if this is the case, it will not threaten my view of type identity of specific beauty. For this specific beauty can only be realized in the conjunction which has gracefulness as a necessary component; otherwise, if a conjunction of substantive property lacks gracefulness, it is hard to imagine that this conjunction of substantive properties could produce this specific beauty. The unlikeness of multiple realizability in the specific beauty is still held because whatever conjunctions there are, they must have the gracefulness as a necessary component in order to make the graceful beauty emerge.

This argument will lead to the idea that the substantive property of gracefulness is also not multiply realizable. There are different ways of being graceful, but for each specific way, there is only one kind of underlying physical arrangement that can realize it.

Conclusion

In my version of realism of beauty, the statement of beauty expresses objective fact. In this sense, when I experience an artwork, I am forming a belief about the object instead of a personal preference. Thus, the belief's truth-value is determined by outward reality, not by my psychological state. This realism is being strengthened through the help of Grice, Zangwill and

Levinson.

In aesthetic experience, we are in the representational state. This kind of state is of the object in reality, in addition, we are in the representational state if we experience the physical, substantive and verdictive properties. In this view, emotion and bodily sensation are excluded. This is the consequence we have to accept. When we dig into the aesthetic experience itself, according to me, there are the sensory experience and the seeing-as experience within the category of phenomenal experience. Although it is hard to draw a clear line between these two kinds of experience, it is certain that in appreciating an artwork, these experiences are of mind-independent properties including the physical, the substantive and the verdictive properties. Thus, when we experience an artwork as beautiful and say ‘x is beautiful’, we are representing a fact based on the view that the properties being experienced are mind-independent.

General beauty belongs to the realm of token identity, whereas specific beauty can only be realized in one substantive property or the conjunction of properties which necessarily contains that specific substantive property. Moreover, each specific substantive property can only be constituted by one kind of physical arrangement. I personally believe that the story is not so simple, perhaps through the aid of cognitive science, we could go farther than we do at present.

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